infidelity to the Jewish specificity." From this, there is also a need to confirm one's difference. And it is the reason why "we find today among so many Jews the need 'to be different' (dissimilar) and the need of a national existence."[2]

At the beginning of the twentieth century, in 1916, the American critic Randolph Bourne, in discussing the failure of the "melting pot" in America, expressed a similar observation: he identified as the "anomaly of the Jews" the feeling of being "culturally and racially peculiar." But at the same time, he admitted that the Jews have proven to be "the most assimilable of all races to other and quite alien cultures."[3]

This Jewish syndrome, the need "to be like everybody" can be applied to a longstanding debate in Israel. Since its creation, from outside as well as from inside it has been expected, or even required, to be a different state, "not as the others," and if possible, an exemplary state. But, at the same time, the aim of its creation was, for many of its pioneers, "to normalize Jewish existence" and for Jews to have a country of their own, as other nations. In fact, while being inspired by other countries, the state of Israel would develop its own culture and original institutions.

It is that form of "assimilation" that the Zionist thinker Ahad Ha'am considered as positive and even creative. In his well-known text entitled "Imitation and Assimilation" (1893), he distinguished between a slavish imitation that destroys a culture and a competitive imitation (positive assimilation). For the Jews, such productive imitation requires a strong central model (the land of Israel).[4]

Some Consequences of Assimilation: "Self-hatred," "Closet identity," and "Marranism"

The long experience of assimilation, this need to erase Jewish visibility, has given rise to two negative attitudes: self-hating Jews and marranism.

It is not necessary to develop here the meaning of "self-hating" Jews. A quote from the feminist historian Gerda Lerner explains a certain context for this phenomenon: living before the rise of Nazism in an assimilated middle-class Jewish family in Vienna, Lerner describes her own family's attitudes. She notes that "self-hatred" is actually a necessary component of assimilation:

> We spoke High German, not Yiddish; in appearance, clothing and education we were not to be distinguished from the gentiles, except for those inescapable physical characteristics that identified some of us immediately as Jews—the dark hair, a certain kind of nose, the

Copyright © 2016. Nebraska. All rights reserved.

Anti-Judaism, Antisemitism, and Delegitimizing Israel, Nebraska, 2016. ProQuest Ebook Central,